Indian spices in their food. Mulligatawny, we learn, was also served at one of the banquets at Queen Elizabeth II's coronation.

It's sociocultural nuggets like these that elevate *Masala Memsahib*. This isn't a customary cookbook, it's a culinary memoir, one that documents the food consultant and writer's explorations in different parts of the country over the past 30-plus years. It blends storytelling with traditional recipes, curated from Anand's friends, family, and chefs from Goa, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Kerala and West Bengal, among other places. The idea for the book came to her in 2020, when the pandemic brought to a halt the farmers' markets that she had been organising in different cities.



"I had time to sit down and collate a lot of information from friends and family. It made me realise that I had not done anything on Indian cuisine in a long time," says the Pune-based author, whose previous books include *Good Food Good Living* and *Lean Cuisine Curries* (reprinted as *Less is More*).

It was in the '90s, roughly a decade after her return from London where she grew up, that Anand began to discover the diversity in Indian food. She travelled the country to discover the world of both home and professional cooks as part of Star TV's show *The Good Food Guide*. "Meeting people and looking at family recipes and homestyle food made me realise that there was so much out there that had not been documented," she says. "Most Indian chefs document restaurant-style food. There are very few who are doing regional recipes."

Anand's intention with *Masala Memsahib* was to not just document recipes from different cultures, but also ensure they were easy to make, or, as she writes, 'a culinary response to fast lives'. She once told the late Jiggs Kalra that while she considered his work on traditional Indian recipes valuable, it took her a week to gather all the ingredients for one. It's why she doesn't include a recipe for biryani in the book. "It's not something I find you can do easily. While there are a few special recipes that are long—like the Nihari (Lucknow lamb shanks) and Kolhapuri mutton, they're not difficult to make."

In the book, **KAREN ANAND'S** intention is to not just document recipes from different cultures, but also ensure they are easy to make

There are fascinating stories behind Anand's encounter with some of the dishes in the book. For instance, when she met the renowned Imtiaz Qureshi—whose forefathers cooked for the Nawabs of Awadh—at a food festival in Lucknow, she wanted to know if he could cook a "simple" recipe that didn't require too many ingredients while still maintaining the integrity of tradition. He asked for a pair of scissors, some chicken breast and basic spices. After a few minutes of mixing and deep-frying, he had whipped up a desi equivalent of KFC's famous fried chicken—called the Kainchi Kebab.

At a time when we're inundated by genetically modified and chemically processed foods, Anand emphasises the importance of knowing where your produce comes from. However, she states that her intention is to not make readers seek out the impossible in the name of authenticity. She offers plenty of substitute ingredient options for readers both in India and abroad. "If you're a Gujarati in New Jersey who's missing home, you can use edamame or fava beans in place of the surti papdi for your Undhiyo. My hope is to offer a genuine and practical cooking approach for every reader." ■

Shikha Kumar

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from appetisers, masalas and pickles to biscuits and desserts, they are all a pleasure to read and tantalising to contemplate making. Home cooks who are new to the cuisine will benefit from carefully reading Talati's context-setting sections, where he explains, for example, how making masalas in Parsi cooking is as foundational as "the use of stocks in European cooking".

Talati believes that "a cookbook should sweep the leaves away to reveal the path to a certain outcome, but how you choose to walk that path should be down to you". While the recipes are easy to follow, a little bit of knowledge of basic Indian cooking techniques is helpful in recreating them; small tweaks, such as changing the type of vessel or portion size, may necessitate experienced adjustments.

With some adaptation to available ingredients, a test of several recipes (roast leg of lamb with garlic and turmeric; kolmi no patyo; papri; mooli and cucumber salad) turned out varied and delicious, leaving the book well-speckled with turmeric—the mark of a successful practical guide.

There are plenty of wonderful Parsi cookbooks out there, from the historic *Vividh Vani* to the near-mythical *Time & Talents Club Recipe Book*, to modern classics like Bhicoo J. Manekshaw's *Parsi Food and Customs*, and more recent memoirish fare, like Anahita Dhondy's *Parsi Kitchen*—just to mention a few. With its diasporic perspective on the cuisine, Talati's *Parsis* adds a new dimension to this collection. ■

Sonal Shah



PARSI: Recipes & Tales from the Ancient Culture
Farokh Talati
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